Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

♠ K 9 5
♥ A Q 2
♦ Q J 10 8 7
♣ 8 3

♠ 6 4
♥ J 10 5 4
♦ 9 4 3
♣ K 7 5 2

♠ 10 8 7 3
♥ K 8 3
♦ 6 2
♣ Q 9 6 4

♠ A Q J 2
♥ 9 7 6
♦ A K 5
♣ A J 10

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♠3

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=1 ♦=5 ♣=1 Total = 11

You need one more winner from the ♥ or ♣ suit. The straight finesse of the ♥K offers a 50% chance of success. The double finesse of the ♣ K Q offers a 75% chance of success. It's a no-brainer. Run 4 ♠s and 5 ♦s ending in your hand. Be very careful not to discard a ♣ from your hand.

You have run the ♠s and ♦s and are in your hand.

East plays low.

A small ♣, playing the ♣10 (or ♣J) when East plays low: the first of your two ♣ finesses. Let's say West wins the ♣K and returns a ♥.

West returns the ♥J.

DO NOT FINESSE THE ♥. Stick with your original 75% plan. Take the ♥A and play your small ♣, finessing the ♣J. This is why you couldn't discard a ♣ earlier.

The single ♥ finesse is an inferior play because its success depends on West holding a specific card, the ♥K.

The double ♣ finesse is much better because its success depends on East holding either of two cards, the ♣Q **OR** the ♣K.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 4 3 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ A 6 5 3 ♣ J 10 9 5	
♠ 6 5 ♥ 10 8 3 ♦ K Q J 10 7 ♣ 8 4 2		♠ K 7 2 ♥ K 9 6 4 ♦ 9 2 ♣ K 7 6 3
	♠ A Q J 10 9 8 ♥ A Q J ♦ 8 4 ♣ A Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

East plays low.

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♦K.

East plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

West has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that West has led from ♦ K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't.

West continues with the ♦Q.

You take it with dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one?

At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K Q J 9 6 5 4 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 5 2 ♣ 7	
♠ — ♥ 10 8 7 3 ♦ K J 9 4 ♣ K 8 6 5 2		♠ 10 2 ♥ K Q J 5 2 ♦ Q 10 8 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ A 8 7 3 ♥ 9 6 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A Q J 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥6 and West the ♥3.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 3

Your only hope for ridding yourself of two of those losers is dummy's ♣ suit. One possibility would be to finesse East for the ♣K, and if that works, discard your ♥ loser on the ♣A. You could then establish another ♣ winner for one of the ♦ losers. The problem with that plan is that if the finesse fails the defense will immediately take the setting ♥ trick.

A better plan is a ruffing finesse. Win the first trick with your ♥A and pull trumps with your ♠ K Q.

East plays low.

Your ♣7 to dummy's ♣A.

The ♣Q from dummy: a ruffing finesse. If West plays the ♣K you will ruff, enter dummy, and discard two red losers on the ♣ J 10. If West plays low instead, you discard your ♥ loser. East may be able to win the trick but you can ruff a ♥ return, and dummy will have two good ♣s on which you can discard 2 ♦ losers.

Ruffing finesses sometimes provide you the best opportunity, like this time.

But they are easy to overlook, mainly because we don't use them often.

Board 4
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 6 5	
♠ K J 3 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ K Q J 9 5 ♣ 8 4	N W E S	♠ 10 8 7 6 ♥ 8 6 4 2 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 10 7 3
	♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 9 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ Q J 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦K

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and East the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If East has the ♠K you can finesse him out of it. Or, you have a two-way finesse for the ♥Q.

It is an easy choice. The defenders only have 12 HCP and West opened the bidding. So you know he must have both of the cards you are interested in.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

West continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and East the ♦8.

West continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and East discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round just to be safe.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

West covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If West doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But West does cover so you take dummy's ♥A, then your other 2 ♥ tricks. The ♠A is your ninth trick.

You might think that a two-way finesse offers you a 50% chance of guessing correctly.

Sometimes that may be right. But there are other times when information from the bidding or the opening lead allows you to make a higher-percentage guess.